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‘Sonic intimacy has particular affordances by virtue of its intangibility and its intrinsic temporal dimension, and because the ear cannot be as choosy as the eye or the hand’ (Dominic Pettman, 2017). Is Pettman right?

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Mediating Intimacy: Space and Intersubjectivity in Recorded Music & Sound

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Introduction

There is something uncomfortably erotic about the way a whisper penetrates your ears through headphones; you can almost feel the warmth of their breath on your skin. The evolution of listening – from vinyl, to speakers, to the birth of portable listening with the Walkman – traces an inevitable pathway towards intimate mediated relationships (Abrantes, 2019). The act of listening evolved from one of community and shared experience, to one of personal, and sometimes secret, curated listening experiences only for your ears. Sonic intimacy is a slippery concept – while the body and mind retain memories of touch and sight, sound cannot be captured by our mind's eye in the same way. Its ability to ignite a deep feeling without physical touch makes hearing a uniquely fragile sense. The nature of intimacy was significantly altered with the rapid growth in popularity of the ASMR industry in the latter half of the 2010s, redefining sonic intimacy as touch rather than merely sound. Not all ASMR is sexual. On the contrary, most of the ASMR industry target their content to those wanting to relieve stress or fall asleep (Andersen, 2015). However, in this essay we will look at how the subgenre of erotic ASMR has captured the internet's attention, sparking questions surrounding our understanding of what is needed to stimulate intimacy in the absence of touch. Pettman is correct in acknowledging the "particular affordances" of sonic intimacy (2017); however, I argue that the highly technological environment that we live in has enabled our ears to become as "choosy as the eye or the hand" through the heavily subjective act of listening.

With the help of the rapid development in microphone technology, ASMRists record every inflection in their voice – every breath, moan, and sigh between their words

– creating an enclosed and embodied listening experience. Where is the boundary between sound and touch? If sound exists in the "temporal dimension" (Pettman, 2017), how does it stimulate such physical feelings? In this essay I will take a particular approach to understanding the nature of sonic intimacy, focusing on the power of the voice and the impact of the erotic ASMR industry on our conception of intimacy.

1. The Nature of Sonic Intimacy

1.1. What is Sonic Intimacy?

We begin our exploration into sonic intimacy by challenging the idea of sound's ephemerality. The eyes have lids, the body can move, but the ear is open and penetrative – as Pettman suggests, the ear cannot hide from sound (2017). Sound is a prison without walls, an intangible entity whose presence is as powerful as it is weak. In her book *Sensing Sound*, Eidsheim explores how acoustic mediation affects our relationship to the self and others, understanding listening as an embodied and affective experience (2015). While Eidsheim views sound from a collective perspective, our examination of sonic intimacy turns inwards, looking at the embodied architecture created within the human psyche rather than in a collective space. This draws upon Gascia Ouzounian's writing on embodied listening (2006), looking at listening as a form of "acoustic architecture" and framing the mind as a site shaped by sonic forces. Although both scholars theorise the construction of sonic spaces, our analysis into sonic intimacy focuses on the boundary between sound and touch, understanding how mediated sonic experiences, especially erotic ASMR, transcend this boundary, manifesting physically. Whether in a public setting, such as an opera house, or within the confines of headphones, sound invades without permission, finding its way into our bodies and wrapping itself around our nerves.

Sound's power comes from its affective disposition, its ability to evoke physical feelings and invites us to create psychic images and influencing our thoughts. However, as

powerful as it is, sound cannot be held, only felt – its touch is temporary, and this temporality is key to Pettman's conceptualisation of sonic intimacy. In the fleeting moments when sound is communicated, we feel the presence of the words and their meaning. In those moments, lives are exchanged and feelings shared – speaking is one of the first ways we present ourselves naked for others to see. Barthes theorises the unique qualities of individual voices through his concept of the "grain of the voice" (Barthes, 1977). The voice carries a bodily presence through inflections such as breaths and textures; the vocal grain transcends the delivery of semantic meaning through physical nuance. Sonic intimacy relies on these bodily aspects of the voice; we are affected not by the language but the grain of the voice itself (ibid, 1977). While speech and its meaning occupy the Lacanian Symbolic register, sound occupies the Imaginary, avoiding linguistic interpretation. This allows us to understand sonic intimacy from a more nuanced lens, drawing meaning from both sound and language. We cannot choose what we hear, but we can choose what we listen to. A declaration of love drowned out by a waling ambulance, a choked apology cut off by stifling tears; sound's affective character gives it power in any situation, regardless of context or intention.

In a world oversaturated by sound, the question remains – if we live in a world filled with sound, can we *truly* choose what we hear? Although not harnessing the surgical precision of sight or touch, our ability to listen subjectively has significantly changed as technology as developed. The era-defining invention of the Walkman in 1979 (Hosokawa, 1984) transformed listening from a social event to a private concert. Headphones revolutionised the ways we receive and understand recorded music, altering the relationship between sound and our bodies by repositioning the epicentre of sound within the mind rather than in the external world. By introducing noise-cancelling technology and wireless headphones, technology has given us an illusion of control and freedom. The sounds we listen to embody us, building castles and towers in our minds, and we have the

power to keep or tear them down (Ouzounian, 2006). Headphones isolate us from the noisy world, serving as a haven from the unwanted clutter. The paradox of safety and isolation birthed a sensory exploration meant to be experienced in candlelight, a sonic intimacy that strokes the ears – an affective mediated relationship between the listener and sound. The voices we hear through our headphones are crafted, rehearsed, and digitalised – they become voices without bodies, severed from their source. This disconnect emphasises the affective power of sound and strengthens the experience of sonic intimacy void of physical presence. Through Carson's understanding of desire as lack (Carson, 2023), we can begin to dig into the true power of sound as a dangerous catalyst for desire.

1.2. Headphones, Intimacy, Embodiment

Picture this: a crowded train at rush hour, people swaying with the motion, desperately avoiding eye contact. Almost everyone wears earphones, but the carriage remains silent. The individual worlds created through the intimacy of headphone collide within the claustrophobic space, yet no one seems affected. The embodied, introspective soundscapes made possible by headphone technology has fundamentally shaped auditory culture.

This moment is a symptom of what Shuhei Hosokawa terms the "Walkman Effect" – the urbanisation of portable listening (Hosokawa, 1984). The Walkman marked a shift in the social relationship between sound and bodies, catalysing new modes of mediated sonic intimacy. However, the industrialisation of sound through headset technology has weakened our relationship with the environment, losing touch with "Gaia's Voice", as Pettman laments (2017). Pettman's metaphor invokes nature's sonic ecology; I use this metaphor to illustrate how mediated sonic intimacy is characterised by sacrificing our relationship with the world for the ones we create within us. We trade bodies for voices when we choose to listen, and as a result the line between body and machine is blurred.

Abrantes argues that sound technologies harness presence in absence, providing intimacy and immediacy through disembodiment or proximity (Abrantes, 2019). The manufactured immediacy of recorded music and streaming services disrupts the delicacy of sonic intimacy, blurring the distinction between real and virtual touch and severing sound from its embodied presence. Our discussion on erotic ASMR will explore how sound is understood as the epitome of unattainable desire, stimulating intimacy through a disembodied-embodied listening paradox.

1.3. The Hypersexualised Ear

"After a long break, the world thus seems to be finding subcultural ways of treating the ear with the kind of erotic respect it deserves, even if only the ears of people with a very specialized interest." – Pettman, 2017, 17

Discussions surrounding sonic intimacy often turn to the ear as a site for erotic stimulation. Branching from Pettman's foundation, Abrantes gave the ear the title of "synecdoche of desire", understanding it as a "gateway" into more complex emotions. While Pettman and Abrantes approach sonic intimacy from different angles, they both conceptualise the ear as a hypersexualised organ. Abrantes touches upon psychoanalysis to build a bridge between ear and voice, looking at the erotic analogies between them. The ear is unique in that it acts as both the receiver of touch and language, blurring the line between the somatic and symbolic. Abrantes cites the Virgin Mary as an example of the early psychoanalytical exploration into the connection between ear and voice. The Virgin Mary is traditionally represented as having conceived through her ear, "upon hearing, accepting, and embodying the divine message" given to her by the archangel Gabriel (2019). This example gives sonic intimacy a more complex, multi-disciplinary foundation; Abrantes builds upon Pettman's exploration into ASMR and audio erotica to look at how the ear serves as an inherently sexual organ.

The act of whispering is intimate — the breath against the skin, the secrecy of the words, and the mystery behind their meaning. The atmosphere surrounding a whisper immediately takes on an intimate lighting, a star in a vast midnight sky; the secret alliance between two people separated from the rest of the world. In *Touching Feeling*, Eva Sedgwick builds on Austin's theory of performative utterance and offers a concept of her own: *the periperformative*. This idea refers to the things that frame a performative act; they are not performative themselves but carry emotional and affective weight. A whisper is a periperformative utterance that frames intimacy through the texture and proximity of the act. Sonic intimacy does not need clear speech, it is defined by the affective power of periperformative utterances. The atmosphere surrounding a whisper — the breath, the tone, the forced closeness — creates *desire*, and this adds to sonic intimacy's unique intangibility. It is the act of refraining from touch, the restraint, that leaves the ear and body longing for more, thus intensifying the affective power of sound. The inherent sensual pull of the voice sparked the development of a "subcultural" way of treating the ear with erotic respect, by completely severing of visual and sonic stimulation through ASMR.

2. ASMR: A New Parasocial Relationship?

2.1. The Rise of a New Digital Age

Autonomous Sensory Meridian Response (ASMR) is a "brainchild of the 21st century" (Tsirblou, 2020, 72), emerging as a pseudo-scientific term in the late 2000s to describe the involuntary bodily sensations triggered by auditory and visual stimuli (Wong, 2020). Early discussions surrounding ASMR in online chatrooms focused on the sleep-inducing and relaxing effect of certain triggers and entered the mainstream through the exponential growth of YouTube in the 2010s. These videos cover a wide range of styles and triggers, including tapping, stroking, eating, role-play scenarios, and drawing. While

most ASMR videos are audio focused, there are roleplay ASMR videos which visually act out scenarios; the movements are calm, and the pace is slow (Wong, 2020) but audio is still the focus.

Koster's (2021) recent ethnographic research explores the complex discussion surrounding ASMR's inherent sensual nature, initiated by the proximity between the speaker and the microphone that is needed to create the certain effect. Drawing on affect she understands that affect involves "relations practiced between people, where (inter)subjective experience based on memory, nostalgia, and intentionality is central" (Koster, 2021, 29). Andersen and Abrantes have similarly analysed how ASMR operates within affective mediated networks, looking at how the manipulation of sonic proximity stimulates affective and erotic responses (Andersen, 2015; Abrantes, 2019). Although the ASMR community strives to be perceived as therapeutic, the nature of this intimate affective relationship between ASMRist and listener cannot escape sensual desire. As previously acknowledged, desire is characterised by lack (Sedgwick, 2003) and in this case, ASMR manipulates emotional affect through the lack of visual or physical stimuli. Koster notes that sexuality is important for the initial attraction to ASMR content, looking at video thumbnails and the gender of ASMRists, but separates this from the affect that is transmitted through specific triggers (Koster, 2021, 29). While this is true for most ASMR, the increasingly popular subgenre of erotic ASMR relies solely on the grain of the voice (Barthes, 1977) for its affective power, using the voice to touch the listener through intimate mediated listening.

2.2. Erotic ASMR and Touch

"Why does the erotic voice lack "stickiness" when it comes to the World Wide Web, given the power of the voice to summon seductive ghosts, quicken the heart, and whisper promises of bliss?" – Pettman, 2017, 18

Pettman poses an interesting question here, looking at the impact of sound on the body and comparing it to the more popular medium of visual erotica. However, in the years after writing this book, erotic ASMR has become more integrated into society as a normalised medium of pleasure. This can be seen through the rise in popularity of apps and websites dedicated to erotic ASMR, one of the most popular being Quinn, launched in 2021. The media popularity of Quinn is reflected in its Instagram audience of over 260,000 people, and its TikTok audience of over half a million. Their social medias have been gaining popularity because of the transparency they provide their online audience. Quinn hosts interview discussions with their voice actors (VAs) on Instagram, giving a face to the voice, an identity to the sounds and imagined images conjured when listening to these audios blind. Unlike the highly criticised and demeaned porn industry, talking about erotic ASMR does not hold the same negative connotations.

Pettman's claim that the "ear cannot be as choosey as the eye or hand" holds truth; while touch and sight can be controlled, hearing is a passive act, and we often hear things before we decide to, thus being open to manipulation. However, with the rise of ASMR, it loses its validity. Users can choose exactly what they want to hear, creating an atmosphere both within the mental and physical world to stimulate sonic intimacy in a highly personal environment. Erotic ASMR achieves intimacy without being pornographic; it replaces explicit visuals with breaths, murmurs, whispers, and moans. The actors hide behind their voices, but the words they say and sounds they construct affective identities for the listener. Pettman's understanding of sonic intimacy assumes passivity; however, users can curate

experiences that embody the type of intimacy they desire. In this sense, sonic intimacy is not about vulnerability, rather about agency; while we cannot choose what we hear, we can, through mediated listening technology, choose what we listen to.

The mediated relationship created by listening to erotic ASMR is interestingly layered, foregrounding the power of the grain of the voice in creating and transmitting affect across bodies. Pettman's question at the start of this section was written prior to the sexual revolution in popular media and equally reflects his understanding of sonic intimacy as strictly temporary and intangible.

3. Case Study: ManicWildcard vs EyesofSuggestion

The paradox of disembodied embodiment is blurred in erotic ASMR – VAs create tactile sonic environments where the boundary between mediated intimacy and reality are constantly tested (Andersen, 2015). The blend of vocal inflections and explicit sounds and movements places VAs in a vulnerable position, breaking down walls of judgement and embarrassment and subsequently creating a safe space for the listener to engage in a sonically intimate parasocial relationship. To understand the approach of erotic ASMRists, I will analyse the styles of two popular erotic VAs, ManicWildcard and EyesofSuggestion, focusing on their output on MagicWave.

ManicWildcard (hereafter Manic) is a VA who specialises in both NSFW and SFW audio roleplays. Feeding into the popular "boyfriend ASMR" phenomenon, Manic's body of work covers a range of scenarios and personas directed towards a female audience. The sonic intimacy he creates through his mediated presence is characterised by its highly personal and embodied approach to sonic eroticism. His use of pet-names such as "baby", "good girl", and "sweetheart" partnered with his use of the second-person pronoun to address the listener are periperformative utterances (Sedgwick, 2003) that close the

distance between his voice and the listener, inhabiting our bodies from the inside. The transmission of affect through mediated sonic intimacy is the cornerstone of ASMR's success; Brennan's conceptualisation of affect adds a theoretical foundation to Manic's curated sonic spaces, rationalising the emotional vulnerability that Manic displays in his efforts to create unique affective spaces of sonic arousal. Through his breath, whispers and tone, Manic heightens sonic intimacy without needing physical presence through the performative and fluid transmission of affect.

Pettman's central claim is that sonic intimacy is temporal and impersonal (2017). However, the work of VAs such as Manic challenges this claim. His archived of performances capture a wide range of attitudes, scenarios, and emotions, making sonic intimacy easily customisable and repeatable. Streaming platforms such as Quinn and MagicWave normalise and commodify the "erotic voice" (Pettman, 2017), redefining the meaning of sonic intimacy as something highly malleable and tangible. Sonic intimacy is now recorded and replayed – the temporal fragility of sonic intimacy that Pettman identifies is neutralised by technology.

Contrary to Manic's approach, EyesofSuggestion (hereafter Eyes) creates affective performances in a messier and more naturalistic way. While he has heavily scripted audios, his most popular output focuses on an improvised style of ASMR. Relying more on natural speech and instinctive movement, Eyes's roleplays embody a different kind of affective power; it leaks out of his body rather than being formally and tactically transferred through mediated listening. His microphone is positioned farther from his body, for example in his most popular audio on MagicWave titled "Mind the Bump!" (EyesofSuggestion, 2024), which creates a more voyeuristic listening experience. Kraugerud's concept of acousmatic intimacy (2020) aligns with this style of erotic ASMR, which creates a feeling of overheard intimacy rather than direct address. Eyes is less performative than Manic, giving his

listeners a more raw but equally intimate listening experience. Trenholm-Jensen et al. argue that the lack of defined boundaries in ASMR provides a "customisable experience which has been shown to accommodate many different needs and desires" (Trenholm-Jensen et al., 2022). The output of Manic and Eyes serve to build on this argument, illustrating how different styles of mediated sonic intimacy build distinct affective environments. Despite a clear difference in style, listeners have the agency to choose which form of intimacy they desire, thus highlighting that Pettman's idea that the ear cannot be choosy (2017) has become less applicable in this new era of sonic intimacy.

Writing before the dawn of erotic ASMR's popularity on social media, Pettman anticipates the erotic power of the voice on the internet, and the bodily desire to treat the ear with the "erotic respect" it deserves (2017). By looking at Manic and Eyes, we can see how Pettman's claims surrounding the limited power of sonic intimacy has been changed through technology.

Conclusion

We are reminded of Pettman's central argument that sonic intimacy is characterised by its "intangibility and intrinsic temporal dimension" and an understanding of the ear's passivity compared to the eye or hand (2017). However, the development of technology and ASMR has proven that sound is embodied, accessible, and reproducible. By understanding the nature of embodied listening through Ouzounian and Eidsheim, this essay began as a journey into mediated sonic intimacy, mapping the acoustic affective environment of the human psyche. The focus then shifted beyond the psyche into the anatomy of the ear and built an understanding of the inherent erotic quality of the ear as an organ, mapping its impact on physical arousal. This exploration logically extended into our discussion surrounding ASMR, specifically erotic ASMR, theorising that the development of headphones and isolated listening experiences has challenged the inherent

temporary quality of sonic intimacy. Extending beyond the confines of this essay lies more complex manifestations of sonic intimacy, mediated through artificial intelligence, building on from the advanced binaural recording technology we have already developed and removing the human subject from ASMR's parasocial relationship altogether.

Through this explorative essay we have concluded that Pettman's framework is outdated, written before the widespread integration of technologically mediated sonic intimacy. While his statement is true for its time, mediated sonic practices today reveal that sonic intimacy is actively curated to feed into affective networks of sonic and physical intimacy – a fundamental shift that demands a revision of Pettman's original claim.

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